

Common Table Expressions (CTEs)

- "Short story" you tell inside a query
 - Exists only while that query runs.
- Defined with `WITH... AS (...)` at the start of a query.
- Not stored in the database - are like "inline views."
- Exists only for the duration of that single query.
- Great for breaking complex queries into readable steps.
- Cannot be indexed or reused outside the query.

Example:

```
WITH sales_2026 AS (  
    SELECT *  
    FROM sales  
    WHERE year = 2026  
)  
SELECT COUNT(*)  
FROM sales_2026;
```

Rule of thumb: Start with a CTE for simple-use logic or recursion.

Switch to a Temp Table if you are handling large volumes of data, need to join the intermediate dataset multiple times or require indexing to optimize performance.

CTE: You combine all at once (its one code)

Temporary table: You can break it down into